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Nordic authoritarianism: Child-rearing values and political behavior in a multiparty context

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Abstract
This article explores how authoritarianism as a factor in child-rearing values (CRV) is associated with political orientation, party support, and policy preferences among voters and societal elites in the Nordic context, which is characterized by social trust and solidarity, feelings of affinity, and a modest degree of ideological polarization. Based on a representative citizen survey conducted in 2018 ($n = 4{,}076$) and an elite survey conducted in 2020 ($n = 948$) among Finnish political, administrative, advocacy, business, and influence elites, our findings suggest that authoritarianism in Finland mostly relates to culturally conservative, and less to economically conservative, political orientations. While authoritarianism is connected to policy preferences and political orientations on both cultural and economic dimensions, it has more relevance for preferences regarding cultural issues than economic ones. Our findings support the notion that authoritarianism plays a role in political orientation mainly in the cultural realm. Overall, our study indicates that authoritarianism as captured by the CRV scale might be a politically important underpinning among both citizens and societal elites also outside the U.S.

KEYWORDS
authoritarianism, child-rearing values, elites, party support, policy preferences, political orientation

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INTRODUCTION

The electoral success of right-wing populist parties (Mols & Jetten, 2016), increasing ideological and affective polarization (Casal Bértoa & Rama, 2021; Dalton, 2021), and the growing significance of cultural conflict in politics (Kriesi & Schulte-Cloos, 2020) have aroused scholarly interest in authoritarianism as a psychological predisposition and underpinning for voters' political choices. Previous studies indicate that the associations between authoritarianism and political behavior and orientation are multifaceted and context dependent (e.g., Federico et al., 2011; Loughran, 2016; Stenner, 2009). However, there is a lack of comprehensive accounts of authoritarianism in differing political and cultural settings, as previous studies have often focused on the U.S. There is a need for both cross-cultural comparative studies and more in-depth examinations focusing on specific countries and cultures. In this study, we explore how authoritarianism surfaces in a Nordic society that is in many ways opposite to the U.S. society and political system.

Although authoritarianism has traditionally been considered to be inherently connected to conservative and right-wing political orientation, the theoretical background of child-rearing values (CRV) as a measure of authoritarianism emphasizes that the associations between authoritarianism and political outcomes can be dependent on several contextual factors (Stenner, 2009). The association between authoritarianism and political preferences can vary depending on, for instance, the composition of public opinion and the degree of political trust, but also on norms which can differ between cultures and societal groups (Stenner, 2009). While many previous studies have focused on authoritarianism in the U.S. and limited their examination to a few aspects of political outcomes at a time (e.g., Bakker et al., 2021; Engelhardt et al., 2021; Knuckey & Hassan, 2020), there is a need for research that describes how authoritarianism affects different aspects of political life in political and cultural contexts outside the U.S. In addition, previous studies have focused on citizens, leaving the question whether societal elites may behave differently unaddressed.

To address these knowledge gaps, we provide an in-depth analysis of authoritarianism in Finland, which in many respects represents a dissimilar case to the U.S. context. Finland has a multiparty system characterized by a relatively high level of social and institutional trust, modest political polarization, and the tradition of the universal Nordic welfare model. Based on a representative citizen survey with 4,076 respondents conducted in 2018, and an elite survey conducted in 2020 with 948 respondents representing Finnish political, administrative, advocacy, business, and influence elites, we explore how authoritarianism, as measured by CRV, is associated with political orientation, party support, and policy preferences among both citizens and societal elites. We are particularly interested in the extent to which authoritarianism is linked to economic (left–right) and cultural (liberal-conservative) dimensions and to political preferences in policy issues such as taxation, same-gender adoption rights, and party support.

FRAMEWORK: CRV AND POLITICAL BEHAVIOR

Child-rearing values as a measure of authoritarianism

Authoritarianism has attracted scholarly interest for several decades, prompting numerous theories, definitions, and empirical operationalizations (for reviews, see Costello et al., 2022; Hetherington & Weiler, 2009). The American National Election Study (ANES) introduced the CRV scale in 1992 as an empirical instrument for measuring authoritarianism as a psychological disposition (Feldman, 2003). Its theoretical background relies largely on the definition of authoritarianism by Feldman and Stenner (1997), understood as a preference for social

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conformity over personal autonomy (see also Feldman, 2003; Stenner, 2009). The theory thus suggests that authoritarians prioritize social conformity, or the reduction of differences between people, and strict adherence to rules and social norms.

Part of the appeal of the CRV scale lies in its simplicity. The original scale consists of only four items. For each item, respondents are offered two qualities (e.g., independence vs. respect for elders) and asked to indicate which one they think is more important for a child to have. One of the paired qualities represents autonomy (e.g., independence) while the other represents social conformity (e.g., respect for elders) (Feldman & Stenner, 1997). The CRV scale is also appreciated for its lack of explicit political content: The CRV approach arguably avoids the ideological biases embedded in some of the other authoritarianism measurements (Engelhardt et al., 2021; Tillman, 2021). However, the CRV scale has been criticized for its narrow perspective and disregard for the multidimensional character of authoritarianism (Bizumic & Duckitt, 2018; Ludeke et al., 2018). Scholars have also raised psychometric concerns due to violations of measurement invariance and differential item functioning characteristics, which make comparisons across groups (e.g., gender, ethnic) potentially problematic (Pérez & Hetherington, 2014; Pietryka & Macintosh, 2022).

Child-rearing values, political orientation, policy preferences, and party support

Traditionally, authoritarianism has been linked to conservative and right-wing political orientations (e.g., Adorno et al., 1950; Altemeyer, 1981, 1996). This reflects the tendency of many studies to measure authoritarianism using scales that tap authoritarian attitudes, rather than treating it as a psychological disposition, thus conflating authoritarianism with political conservatism. When conceptualized as a psychological predisposition, as the CRV scale does, authoritarianism may be perceived as a fairly stable individual trait that can affect attitudes and behavior differently depending on contextual factors and individuals' social positions.

The theoretical background of the CRV scale also points towards a multifaceted understanding of political orientation. Stenner (2009) emphasizes the distinction between two conservative psychological dispositions: laissez-faire and status quo conservatism. Laissez-faire conservatism focuses on the role of the state in the economic domain, with no direct link to authoritarianism as such. Status quo conservatism opposes social change and may thus be positively linked to authoritarianism. This two-dimensional approach has received support from studies indicating that distinct measures for economic and cultural dimensions better capture the ways individuals organize their political values and preferences than the often-used unidimensional liberal-conservative continuum (e.g., Feldman & Johnston, 2014; Malka et al., 2017; Treier & Hillygus, 2009). On the economic dimension, the left end prefers the government to play an active role in the economic realm, while the right end aims to reduce the government's role in economic issues. On the cultural dimension, the liberal end advocates for social or cultural change, while the conservative end prefers the maintenance of the status quo. As the terms “right wing” and “conservative” are often used interchangeably, we will use the terms “economic conservatism” when referring to right-wing views on the economic dimension and “cultural conservatism” when referring to conservative views on the cultural dimension to avoid confusion.

While political psychology has customarily treated political orientation as a unidimensional construct, those few studies that take both dimensions into account support the notion that authoritarianism may have a weaker association with voters' economic orientation than their positioning on the cultural dimension (Costello & Lilienfeld, 2021; Stenner, 2009). The same applies to the link between authoritarianism and policy preferences. Citizens with authoritarian leanings often hold negative attitudes towards minorities, oppose abortion, and support strong leadership and harsher criminal punishments (e.g., Bakker et al., 2021; Engelhardt

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et al., 2021; Feldman, 2020; Luttig, 2017; Miller et al., 2017; Smith & Hanley, 2018). Limited research on economic issues indicates that authoritarianism might not be associated with economic policy preferences (Bakker et al., 2021).

Like political orientation and policy preferences, party support is connected to authoritarianism in a multifaceted manner. In the United States, while authoritarians usually identify themselves as Republicans (e.g., Knuckey & Hassan, 2020; Wronski et al., 2018; but see also Bakker et al., 2021), authoritarianism has also been associated with extreme partisanship among both Democrats and Republicans (Luttig, 2017). European authoritarianism has been linked to voting for right-wing parties (Vasilopoulos & Lachat, 2018), although authoritarians can be found on both the political right and left (Federico et al., 2017). Some studies have suggested that authoritarianism predicts voting for radical right-wing populist parties, but findings have been inconsistent across countries (Dunn, 2015; Tillman, 2021). Similarly, Loughran (2016) found that authoritarianism is generally associated with increased support for Christian democratic parties and decreased support for green parties, but there is substantial variation between countries and cultural contexts.

The link between authoritarianism and political orientation also appears to be sensitive to contextual factors. The meaning of ideological labels such as "liberal" or "conservative" and "left" or "right" differs across societies and political settings. In liberal democracies, cultural conservatism often signals a desire to preserve traditional values that promote conformity and oppose diversity. In such contexts, authoritarians are likely to identify as cultural conservatives. While authoritarianism at its core concerns the relationship between an individual and their group, a central determining factor of the correlates of authoritarianism is *which* groups the individual identifies with. Authoritarians' policy preferences can therefore vary with their perceptions of ingroups (with whom they identify) and outgroups (outsiders) (cf. Tajfel & Turner, 1979/2004). Different groups can consider different authorities as legitimate, different norms as enforceable, and different transgressors as punishable (Stenner, 2009).

The expected outcomes of specific policies also affect how those high or low in authoritarianism might endorse them. Authoritarians may prefer policies usually considered liberal if they reduce societal differences and contribute to social cohesion. For instance, authoritarianism can *increase* support for affirmative action for ethnic minorities if it is perceived as reducing the differences between ethnic groups (see Stenner, 2009, p. 155). Similarly, those low in authoritarianism can sometimes enforce policies that sacrifice individual freedoms for the benefit of the community, as has happened in some countries regarding the COVID-19 pandemic (Vowles, 2022) and climate change (Hirsch, 2022) policies.

Individual-level characteristics might also modify the relationship between authoritarianism and its political expressions. The two most important characteristics in the context of our study are political trust and political engagement. Stenner (2009) notes that societal circumstances, such as the composition of public opinion and the degree of political trust, condition the association between authoritarianism and political orientation. Authoritarianism and conservatism should align, particularly when public opinion is dispersed or polarized and citizens' confidence in political institutions is low. However, the interaction between political trust and authoritarianism with respect to political orientation, attitudes, or party support has not been studied extensively. A recent study from New Zealand indicates that during the COVID-19 pandemic a subset of authoritarians who also have high levels of political trust was more inclined to shift towards voting for a left-wing government party (Vowles, 2022). This provides tentative evidence for the importance of political trust as a modifying factor in the relationship between authoritarianism and political outcomes. Previous studies indicate that political engagement strengthens the association between authoritarianism and conservatism (e.g., Federico et al., 2011). This might stem from exposure to "elite cues" associated with different ideological orientations or policy or party preferences. Individuals with more political

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knowledge might have different views on which issue orientations "go together" and what various ideological labels mean than those with less political knowledge.

In conclusion, while authoritarianism has traditionally been associated with conservative ideology and policy preferences as well as support for extreme right-wing parties, more recent findings paint a more nuanced picture, where associations between authoritarianism and political outcomes can be varied and highly dependent on the context as well as an individual's characteristics. This highlights the need for systematic accounts from different political and cultural contexts and analyses of the links between authoritarianism and political orientation, party support, and policy preferences among both citizens at large and societal elites.

Authoritarianism in Finland

Finland offers an interesting political and societal context to study the link between authoritarianism and political behavior. Built on the Nordic welfare model, Finland is one of the most egalitarian countries in the world, characterized by high levels of social trust, social cohesion, a sense of intergroup solidarity, and feelings of affinity (e.g., Hall, 2017; Pontusson, 2021). Progressive welfare policies are supported by a trilateral corporatist wage bargaining system. Finland's open-list proportional representation with mandatory preferential voting leads to multiparty governments and has promoted a consensual decision-making culture. There is less ideological polarization in Finland than in many other European countries (Casal Bértoa & Rama, 2021; Dalton, 2021), although affective polarization has been increasing lately (Kekkonen & Ylä-Anttila, 2021). Moreover, voters tend to prefer candidates who are aligned with their parties' position on both the left–right and liberal-conservative dimensions (Isotalo et al., 2020), contributing to a moderate political culture.

As trust in institutions is relatively high in Finland and political polarization is low, we might expect only a weak association between an authoritarian disposition and culturally conservative political ideology. The Nordic welfare state with its universal social benefits and public services has largely been the result of consensual policies after World War II and is generally highly valued by citizens (Ahrens & Bandau, 2022; Hübscher et al., 2021). It thus seems plausible to expect that even those scoring high in authoritarianism may find welfare-state policies valuable and worth preserving, although previous studies have not found a consistent association between authoritarianism and issue preferences on the economic dimension.

The Finnish multiparty context offers several ways in which authoritarianism could be expected to be associated with party support. On the basis of previous studies, we can expect those scoring high in authoritarianism to gravitate towards the most culturally conservative parties, that is, the Christian Democrats and the Finns Party, and to steer away from the more liberal parties such as the Greens, the Left Alliance, and the Swedish People's Party (e.g., Loughran, 2016). However, it is also possible that authoritarians might favor the traditional "big three," that is, the Social Democratic Party, the Centre Party, and the National Coalition Party, parties that used to gain a notably higher share of votes than the other parliamentary parties. The high levels of political trust might mean that authoritarians are more prone to supporting parties perceived as a stable part of the political system, rather than voting for their smaller counterparts or a populist challenger.

While authoritarianism has been studied in different political settings, there is little evidence of how its effects on political outcomes might differ between citizens and societal elites. Finland has the most cohesive elites among the Nordic countries (Ruostetsaari, 2022). While the Nordic welfare model has developed around a unifying "all-in-the-same-boat" narrative, recent findings from the wealth elite literature suggest that the economically privileged may be developing distinct upper-class identities and cultures, with a growing distance from less advantaged groups and critical perceptions of these (Hecht et al., 2020; Kantola, 2020; Kantola & Kuusela, 2019; Savage, 2015; Suhay et al., 2021). As previous studies have found that the association between

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authoritarianism and conservatism is stronger among those who are more politically astute (Federico et al., 2011), there might also be a stronger association between authoritarianism and conservative views among elites compared to citizens. Elites might differ from average citizens in terms of the groups they identify with, what they consider to be the societal norms, or their perceptions of the expected outcomes of specific policies. These factors in turn might affect both the level of authoritarianism and its associations with policy preferences.

METHODS

Sample

Our analyses are based on one survey conducted among citizens and another conducted among societal elites. The nationally representative cross-sectional survey of citizens was conducted in three stages during the spring of 2018. The first stage comprised an online survey of 20,000 people, randomly sampled from a national population register (response rate of 12.1%). As pensioners and the higher educated were overrepresented, the second stage targeted 13,197 people from underrepresented sociodemographic groups for in-person or phone interviews (response rate of 7.6%). As lower-educated persons of working age remained underrepresented, in a third step, 4,214 participants from an Internet panel were contacted ($n = 40{,}000$, response rate of 16.2%). The final dataset comprised 4,076 respondents. We checked our sample against the national population for representativeness and generated weights that adjusted for gender, age, and place of residence. The weighted sample represents the population adequately. The comparison of unweighted sample characteristics and the population are presented in the online supporting information (S1).

The cross-sectional survey of elites across several fields of activity, including administrative, advocacy, business, and influence elites, was conducted in the fall of 2020. We selected individuals holding leading positions or with significant influence on policymaking in top institutions and organizations with significant dominance. These individuals represented five sectors: politics (e.g., members of parliament, ministers' special advisers), government (e.g., municipal chief executives, ministries' permanent secretaries), business (e.g., CEOs of the largest Finnish companies, board members of labor market organizations), research and education (e.g., rectors of universities, management of state research institutes), and media (e.g., management of the public broadcasting company Yleisradio, editors-in-chief of the largest national media companies). This strategy followed the procedure set out in several survey studies targeted at elites (e.g., Bunselmeyer et al., 2013; Hartmann, 2013; Hoffmann-Lange, 1992; Teney & Helbling, 2014). The survey was sent to 3,580 individuals (response rate of 19.6%). Our response rate falls within the range of previous similar surveys (Best, 2012; Hoffmann-Lange, 2018).[1] A total of 701 respondents completed the survey and a further 247 responded partially, yielding a sample size comparable to that of other such surveys.[2] Surveys of elites frequently suffer from overrepresentation of certain sectors (see Bunselmeyer et al., 2013; Teney & Helbling, 2014). In our sample, business and political sectors were overrepresented. We therefore calculated two weights based on Ruostetsaari's (2022, p. 118) counts of the number of Finnish elites in different sectors: one from 2021 and the other based on the average from 1992 to 2021. The results did not differ substantially between the two weights. We report the results using the first weight, as it is closer in time to the elite survey. The results for the average weight are reported in the online supporting information (S5).

[1]For example, Best's (2012) study yielded a response rate of 13.7%, whereas Bunselmeyer et al.'s (2013) study yielded a response rate of 37.0%.

[2]For example, the Bunselmeyer et al. (2013) study consists of 956 respondents, whereas Teney and Helbling's (2014) study includes 354 respondents.

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For each analysis, respondents with missing values were excluded. The final sample sizes for each analysis are reported in the statistical analyses section.

Measures

We measured our main independent variable, that is, authoritarianism, using the four-item CRV scale. Respondents in both surveys were presented with four pairs of attributes and asked to indicate which of each pair they considered more important: (1) "A child should be self-reliant" versus "A child should respect elder persons"; (2) "A child should be curious" versus "A child should be well-behaved"; (3) "A child should be obedient" versus "A child should be independent"; and (4) "A child should think for themselves" versus "A child should have good manners." A third response option, "do not know," was also available in the citizen survey. The final responses were coded "1" for more authoritarian values ("respect for elders," "well-behaved," "obedient," "good manners") and "0" for less authoritarian values ("self-reliant," "curious," "independent," "think for themselves"). "Do not know" was coded as .5. This scale corresponds closely to that used in the ANES (Feldman, 2003). We calculated a sum variable by taking the sum of the four individual items to be used in the regression analyses and analyses of covariance.

To examine the convergent validity of our measure, we also measured authoritarian political attitudes in the citizen survey with two items asking respondents how much they agreed with the statements, "The punishments for criminals are currently much too lenient in Finland" and "Finland needs a strong leader." The response options ranged from 1 (*completely disagree*) to 5 (*completely agree*) with no "do not know" option available.

Our main dependent variables were three aspects of political behavior. To measure political orientation, we used self-assessed positions on the left–right and liberal-conservative continuums. For both questions, respondents were asked to place themselves on a scale ranging from 0 (*left/liberal*) to 10 (*right/conservative*). The option "do not know" was also available for citizens and coded as "missing."[3] These questions were asked of both citizens and elites.

We measured party support by asking respondents which party they would vote for if the parliamentary elections were held now. The response options in both surveys included the eight main parliamentary parties. The National Coalition, Centre Party, Swedish People's Party and Christian Democrats are considered economically conservative, whereas the Social Democratic Party and the Left Alliance constitute the main leftist parties. The Green League and the Finns Party represent culturally liberal and conservative alternatives, respectively, on the cultural dimension (cf. Kriesi & Schulte-Cloos, 2020). In addition, respondents could choose "some other party" or "do not know."

Two minor populist parties were included in the surveys. Blue Reform was included only in the citizen survey,[4] while Movement Now and "I would not vote" were included only in the elite survey.[5] Very few responses indicated a willingness to vote for Movement Now or Blue Reform, so these were merged with "some other party." "Do not know" and "I would not vote" were coded as "missing."

To capture policy preferences, both citizen and elite respondents were asked if they agreed with various statements covering, for example, income differences, employment, taxation, and migrants. Different sets of items were used for the citizens and elites. The most noteworthy

[3]Only 24 respondents in the citizen survey chose the option "Do not know." These respondents ($M = 2.02$, $SD = 1.30$). were slightly more authoritarian compared to the final sample ($M = 1.74$, $SD = 1.29$).

[4]Blue Reform is an offshoot of the Finns Party, founded in 2017 shortly before the data collection for the citizen survey.

[5]Movement Now was represented in the parliament at the time of the elite survey.

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difference is that questions on gender and sexual minorities' rights were available only in the citizen survey, while a question on climate change was only included in the elite survey. The response options in both surveys ranged from 1 (*completely disagree*) to 5 (*completely agree*) with no "do not know" option available. We computed sum variables for policy preferences based on the results of exploratory factor analysis (using varimax rotation and maximum likelihood estimation), representing the mean of the items with the strongest loading on each corresponding factor. For the citizens, the resulting policy preference variables were: (1) economic policy preferences, (2) cultural policy preferences, and (3) benefiting from economic globalization (economic globalization). For the elites, the policy preference variables were: (1) economic policy preferences, (2) cultural policy preferences, and (3) climate change opinions (climate change). The economic and cultural preference sum variables were coded so that larger values represent economically and culturally conservative positions, respectively. The full results of the factor analyses and the complete list of items are presented in the online supporting information (S3).

Variables measuring respondents' sociodemographic and socioeconomic characteristics included gender (1 = man, 2 = woman), age (18–24, 25–34, 35–49, 50–64, 65–79, 80+ in the citizen survey; continuous in the elite survey), level of education (1 = comprehensive school, 2 = vocational school, 3 = upper secondary school, 4 = postsecondary level, 5 = university of applied sciences, 6 = university), and monthly personal gross income (ranging from 1 = less than €500 per month to 10 = more than €10,000 per month in the citizen survey; continuous in the elite survey). Respondents could also answer "other" for gender and "do not want to disclose" or "do not know" for the gender, level of education, and income. These responses were coded as "missing."

Both surveys were available in Finnish or Swedish, and the respondents were free to choose their language of choice.

Statistical analyses

We assessed measurement invariance between the citizens and the elites by using multigroup confirmatory factor analysis. The "do not know" responses from the citizen survey were coded as "missing," as this option was not available in the elite survey. Only respondents with no missing values for the CRV scale were included in this analysis. The final sample included 4,630 respondents (3,899 citizens and 731 members of elites). As many popular survey scales used in political psychology research have been found to lack measurement variance between genders (Pietryka & Macintosh, 2022), we also assessed the measurement invariance between men and women. For this analysis, only respondents with no missing values in the variables indicating gender or the CRV scale were included, leading to a final sample of 3,848 respondents.

We evaluated configural invariance, that is, the assumption that the factor structure is the same across groups, by fitting the model to the data for each group separately. We used cut-off values of the fit indices CFI >.95, SRMS <.05, and RMSEA <.06 indicating a good fit. Next, we fitted four hierarchically nested models into the data, placing increasingly stringent restrictions on the parameter estimates to assess metric, scalar, and strict invariance. In the configural model, the same pattern of fixed and free factor loadings was estimated simultaneously for both groups. In the metric model, factor loadings were fixed to be equal across groups. In the scalar model, the intercepts were forced to be equal across groups, and in the strict model, the residual variances were forced to be equal across groups. We compared the fit indices of the more stringent model with those of the less stringent model in the previous step (i.e., the metric model was compared to the configural model, the scalar to the metric, and the strict to the scalar). Invariance was assumed to hold if the fit indices did not differ substantially. We focused on RMSEA, CFI, and SRMR as indicators of substantial difference in the model fits, since the X^2 values and likelihood ratio tests are very sensitive to sample size and produce significant values in large samples,

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even when the absolute changes are small. A change of <.010 in CFI, >.15 in RMSEA, and >.030 in SRMR when assessing the metric invariance, and a change of <.010 in CFI, >.15 in RMSEA, and >.010 in SRMR when assessing the scalar and strict invariance were considered to indicate noninvariance, as recommended by Chen (2007).

To test convergent validity, we conducted a confirmatory factor analysis using the CRV items and the two authoritarian political attitude items from the citizen survey. Only respondents with no missing values in the items analyzed were included. The final sample included 3,899 respondents. We fit a two-factor model to the data, the first factor being the CRV scale items and the second the two alternative items measuring authoritarian attitudes. We used cutoff values of CFI>.95, SRMS <.05, and RMSEA <.06 to indicate a good fit. We also assessed the correlation between the factors to determine convergent validity. As the scales should measure similar but distinct constructs (i.e., authoritarian disposition and authoritarian attitudes), the two factors should be somewhat, but not highly, correlated.

To test the association between authoritarianism, political orientation, and policy preferences, we estimated five separate regression models for both citizens and elites. The dependent variables included variables indicating policy preferences and measures for left–right and liberal-conservative orientation, while the independent variables included the CRV sum variable, age, gender, level of education, and income. We report both unstandardized (*B*) and standardized (β) regression coefficients. Only respondents with no missing values in the relevant variables were included (3,831 citizens and 704 members of elites). We conducted these analyses with and without applying the previously mentioned weights, and the results did not differ substantially. We report the results without weights. The results using the weights are reported in the online supporting information (S4).

Finally, to assess the association between the CRV and party support, we used a two-way analysis of covariance (ANCOVA) with the mean of the CRV items as the dependent variable, and party support and gender as the independent variables, while controlling for age, education, and income. The aim of these analyses was to assess whether the voters of some parties have more authoritarian tendencies than others. We included gender as an independent variable because gender is an important determinant of authoritarianism (e.g., Brandt & Henry, 2012). Again, these analyses were conducted separately for voters and elites. We applied the previously described weights in both analyses. As there were very few responses for some of the party-support categories in the elite survey, we excluded respondents who indicated voting for "some other party" and did not include an interaction between party support and gender in the final analysis. For the analysis of the elite survey data with a linear measure of age, we also included age squared in the model to allow for nonlinear relationships. For both analyses, only respondents with no missing values in the relevant variables were included. The final samples comprised 3,302 citizens and 444 elites.

R Version 4.2.0 (R Core Team, 2022) was used for all analyses. The software packages *lavaan* (Rosseel, 2012) and *equaltestMI* (Jiang & Mai, 2021) were used for confirmatory factor analyses, *lm.beta* (Behrendt, 2022) for regression analyses, and *car* (Fox & Weisberg, 2019) for the analyses of covariance.

RESULTS

Measurement invariance

Table 1 presents the results for the multigroup confirmatory factor analysis examining the measurement invariance between citizens and elites, with the X^2 values and fit indices for each model.

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TABLE 1 Results of the multigroup confirmatory factor analysis between citizens and elites.

Model	X^2	*df*	CFI	RMSEA	SRMR
Overall model	10.988	2	.996	.031	.011
General population model	7.049	2	.997	.025	.008
Elites model	3.644	2	.994	.034	.014
Configural model	10.693	4	.996	.027	.009
Metric model	18.296	7	.994	.026	.013
Scalar model	28.736	10	.990	.028	.017
Strict model	158.651	14	.920	.067	.046

Abbreviations: CFI, comparative fit index; RMSEA, root mean square error of approximation; SRMR, standardized root mean squared residual.

The model fits the data well for the general population (CFI = .997, RMSEA = .025, SMRS = .008) and elites (CFI = .994, RMSEA = .034, SMRS = .014) separately. The metric model did not show substantially worse fit for the data compared to the configural model (ΔCFI = .002, ΔRMSEA = .001, and ΔSRMR = .004), the scalar model showed no substantial change in fit compared to the metric model (ΔCFI = .004, ΔRMSEA = .002, and ΔSRMR = .004), and the strict model showed no substantial change in fit compared to the scalar model (ΔCFI = .07, ΔRMSEA = .039, and ΔSRMR = .029).

The results of the analysis comparing men and women is presented in the online supporting information (S2). Partial invariance was established for men and women, when the intercepts of one item were allowed to vary freely. The results indicate that men are more likely to value obedience than women, but this is not attributable to differences in authoritarianism.

Convergent validity

We examined convergent validity by fitting a two-factor model to the data with the child-rearing items loading on one factor and the alternative authoritarian attitude items loading on the other. The two-factor model with the loadings is illustrated in Figure 1.

The two-factor model fits the data well ($X^2(8) = 54.334$, $p < .001$, CFI = .983, RMSEA = .038, SRMR = .021). The standardized loadings of items on the child-rearing factor and the alternative authoritarianism factor fell within the ranges .50–.57 and .61–.63, respectively. The correlation between the two factors was .55, supporting the notion that the items measure similar yet distinct constructs. This accords with the view that the CRV scale measures authoritarian disposition, which is connected to but distinct from authoritarian political attitudes (Feldman & Stenner, 1997). Overall, our results support the idea that the CRV scale can be used to assess differences in authoritarianism across groups in Finland.

Child-rearing values, political orientation, and policy preferences

We then examined the association between the CRV scale, policy preferences, and political ideology by fitting five separate linear regression models for both, citizens and elites, using the left–right identification, the liberal-conservative identification, and the policy preferences as dependent variables. The results for each model are presented in Figure 2 for citizens and Figure 3 for elites.

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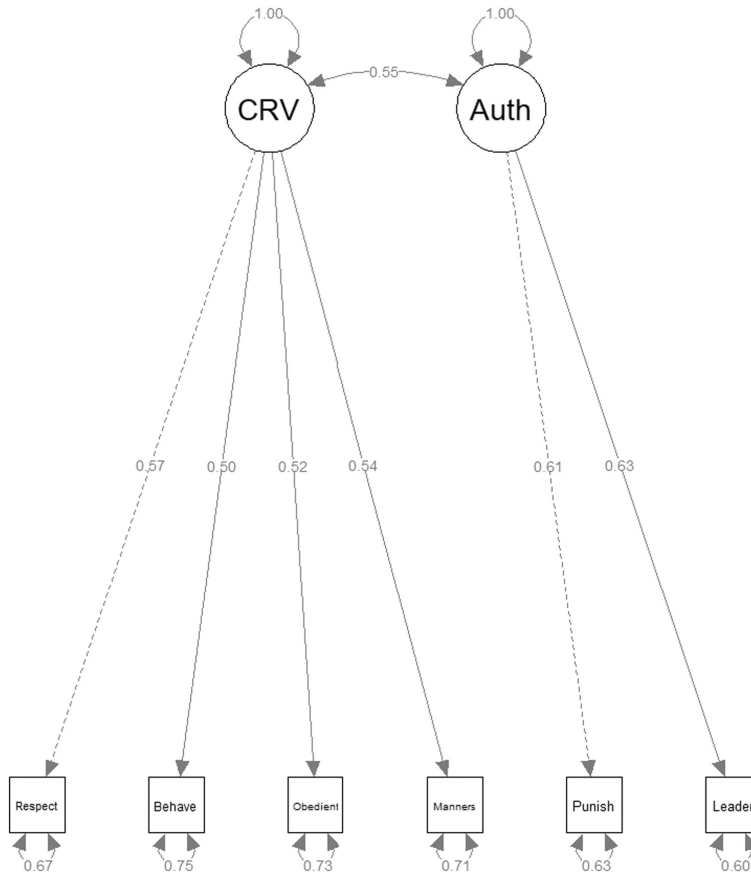

FIGURE 1 Correlation between latent variables and factor loadings of each item for the two-factor model. Values indicate standardized parameter estimates. Squares represent measured variables and circles latent variables. A dash-line indicates a marker variable with a loading fixed to 1. Auth, authoritarian political attitudes; CRV, child-rearing values.

For citizens, the mean score of the CRV items is statistically significantly associated with both cultural ($B = .22$, $\beta = .29$, $p < .001$) and economic ($B = .08$, $\beta = .14$, $p < .001$) policy preferences, albeit more strongly with cultural preferences. The more authoritarian responses are connected to more culturally and economically conservative policy preferences, as well as respondents indicating that they had benefited less from economic globalization ($B = -.09$, $\beta = -.10$, $p < .001$). As with the policy preferences, authoritarian responses are also connected to identifying as more conservative on the cultural ($B = .40$, $\beta = .24$, $p < .001$) and economic dimensions ($B = .27$, $\beta = .16$, $p < .001$). These associations are of similar magnitude as those of the corresponding policy preferences.

The results are similar for the decision-makers: The mean score of the CRV items is statistically significantly associated with both cultural ($B = .18$, $\beta = .24$, $p < .001$) and economic ($B = .10$, $\beta = .15$, $p < .001$) policy preferences, again, somewhat more strongly with cultural preferences. The more authoritarian responses are connected to more culturally and economically conservative policy preferences, as well as respondents indicating *less* that Finland should be an international leader in reducing greenhouse gases ($B = -.25$, $\beta = -.23$, $p < .001$). As with the policy preferences, authoritarian responses are also connected to identifying as more conservative on the cultural ($B = .88$, $\beta = .45$, $p < .001$) and economic ($B = .41$, $\beta = .21$, $p < .001$) dimensions.

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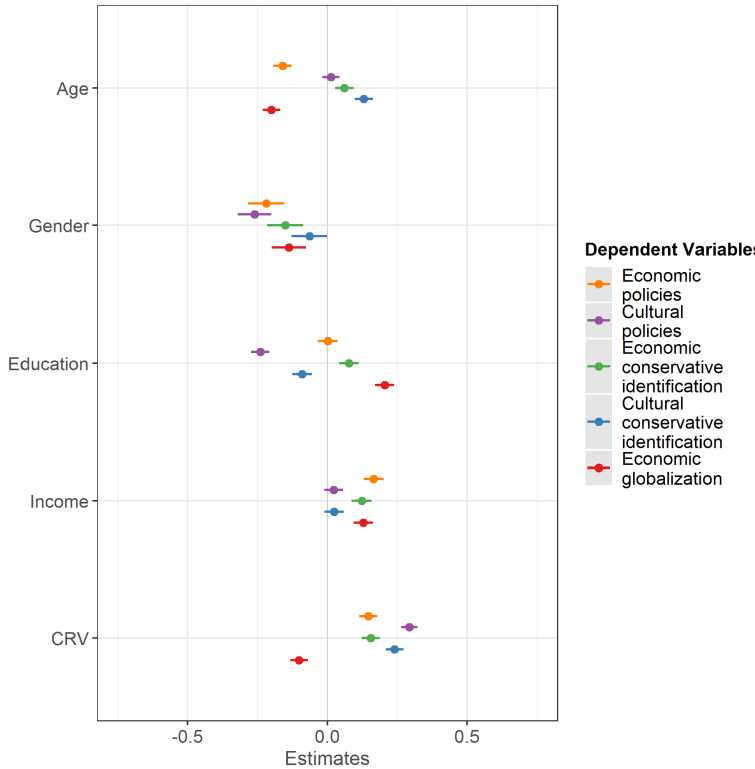

FIGURE 2 Results of regression models for citizens with authoritarianism predicting policy preferences and political orientation. CRV = mean of child-rearing value items. Estimates are standardized regression coefficients and the 95 percent confidence intervals from five separate regression models.

However, unlike with the citizens, the associations between CRV and ideological identification are stronger than between CRV and corresponding policy preferences.

Child-rearing values and party support

We addressed the association between CRV and party support using a two-way analysis of covariance for citizens and elites separately. The full results are presented in Table 2 for citizens and Table 3 for elites. In both groups, there was a significant association between CRV and party support after controlling for age, level of education, and income. However, gender had no statistically significant effect in either group, and the interaction between gender and party support among the citizens was not significant.

As can be seen from Figures 4 and 5, supporters of the Christian Democrats and the Finns Party are the most authoritarian, while Green League and Left Alliance voters are the least. The pairwise comparisons between supporters of each party are presented in Table 4 for the citizens and Table 5 for the elites. Among citizens, voters for the Finns Party are more authoritarian than voters for most other parties, except for the Centre Party and Christian Democrats. Voters for the Christian Democrats are more authoritarian than voters for the Green League, the Left Alliance, and the Swedish People's Party but do not differ statistically significantly from voters for the traditional "big three" parties. Voters for the Centre Party, the National Coalition, and the Social Democratic Party indicate similar levels of authoritarianism but are more authoritarian than supporters of the Left Alliance and the Swedish People's Party.

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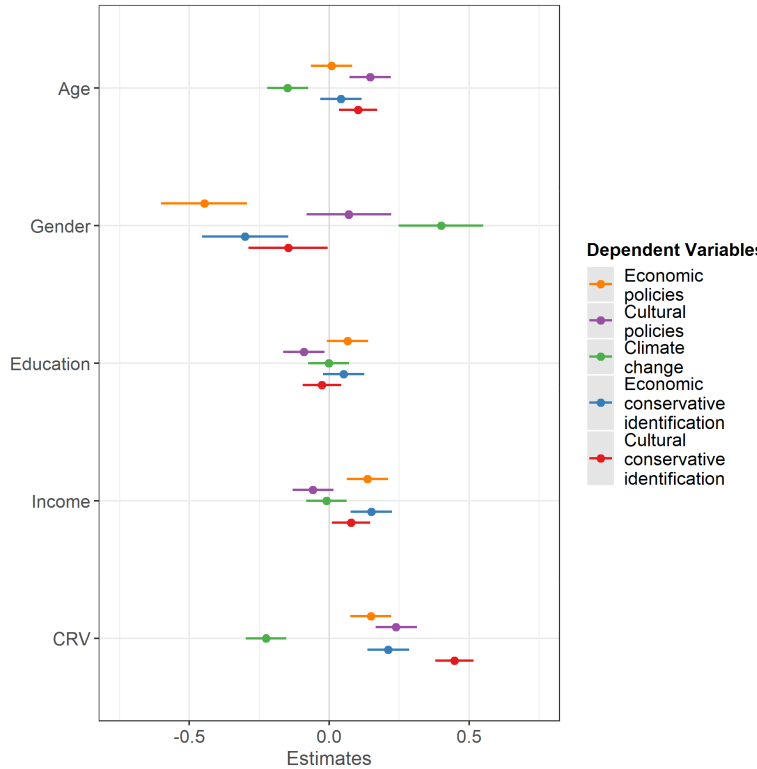

FIGURE 3 Results of regression models for elites with authoritarianism predicting policy preferences and political orientation. CRV = mean of child-rearing value items. Estimates are standardized regression coefficients and their 95 percent confidence intervals from five separate regression models.

TABLE 2 ANCOVA results for citizens.

Variable	*df*	SS	MS	*F*	*p*	η_p^2
Party support	8	117.31	14.66	9.71	<.001	.022
Gender	1	.35	.35	.23	.630	.000
Age	1	16.81	16.81	11.13	.001	.003
Education	1	164.02	164.02	108.56	<.001	.031
Income	1	.80	.80	.53	.468	.000
Party support*gender	8	9.13	1.14	.76	.642	.002
Residuals	3381	5108.56	1.51			

Among the elites, Christian Democrat voters are more authoritarian than the supporters of all other parties, except for the Finns Party. Finns Party voters are more authoritarian than voters for the National Coalition, the Social Democratic Party, the Green League, and the Left Alliance. Notably, supporters of the National Coalition and the Social Democratic Party are not more authoritarian than voters for the smaller parties among the elites, as is the case among the citizens. However, Centre Party and Swedish People's Party supporters are more authoritarian than Green League and Left Alliance voters.

These results support Stenner's (2009) notion that authoritarianism is associated with cultural (or status quo) conservatism, but not economic conservative orientation (or laissez-faire conservatism). The two parties with the voters who are most authoritarian, the Christian

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TABLE 3 ANCOVA results for elites.

Variable	*df*	SS	MS	*F*	*p*	η_p^2
Party support	7	176.54	25.22	10.26	<.001	.143
Gender	1	.06	.06	.03	.872	.000
Age	1	.20	.20	.08	.779	.000
Age squared	1	.00	.00	.00	.976	.000
Education	1	13.99	13.99	5.69	.017	.013
Income	1	.62	.62	.25	.616	.001
Residuals	431	1059.65	2.46			

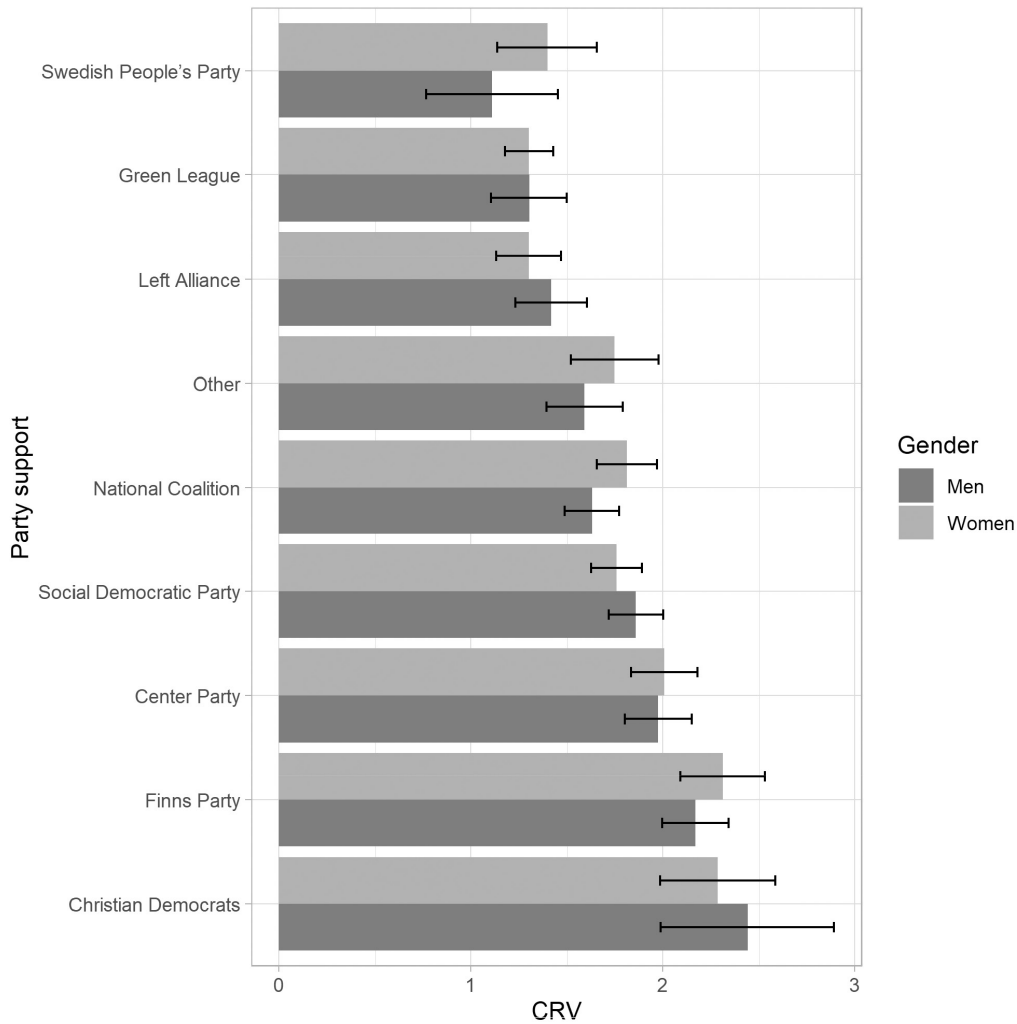

FIGURE 4 Means and 95 percent confidence intervals of authoritarianism by party support and gender among voters. CRV = sum of child-rearing value items.

Democrats and the Finns Party, position themselves as protectors of traditional values. This can appear as opposing social change (e.g., same-sex couples' right to marry), which accords with Stenner's (2009) definition of status quo conservatism. However, there is no clear indication of a left–right divide in authoritarianism. For example, voters for the Social Democratic

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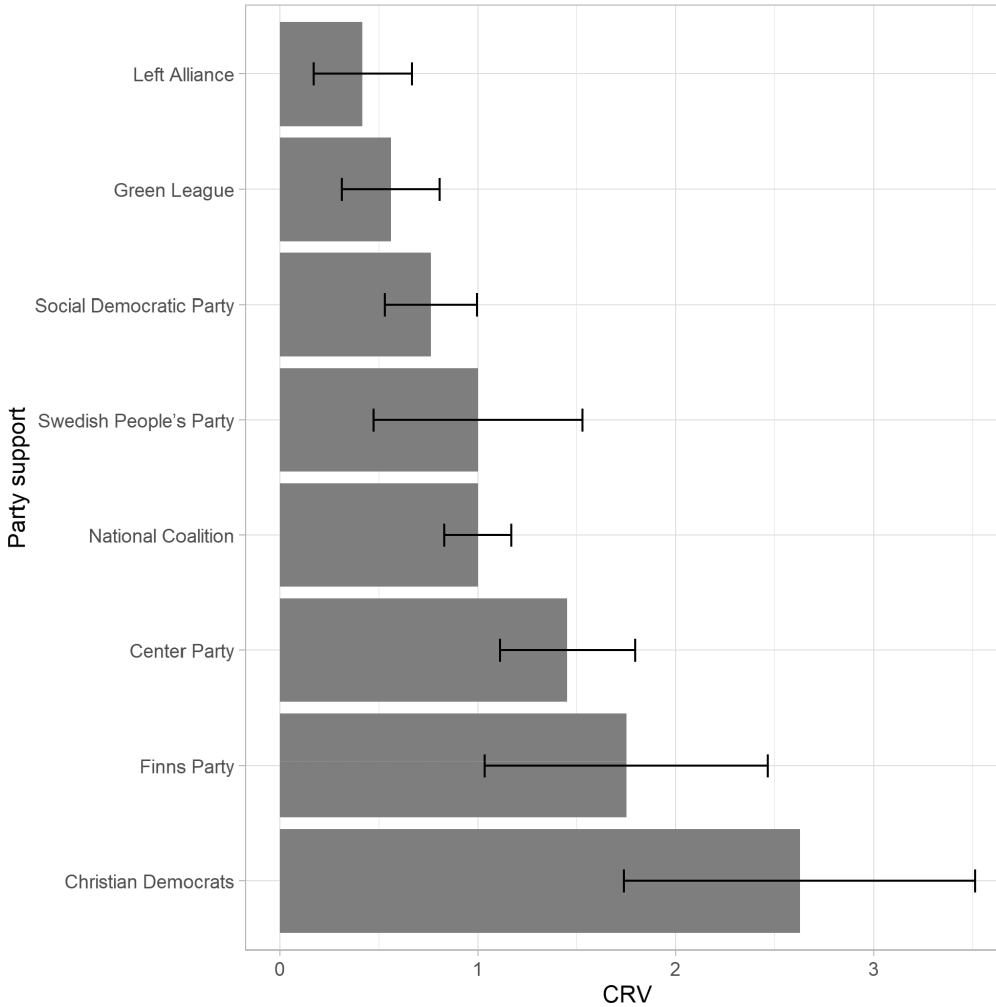

FIGURE 5 Means and 95 percent confidence intervals of authoritarianism by party support among elites. CRV = sum of child-rearing value items.

Party and the National Coalition do not differ in authoritarianism. Moreover, voters of one of the most economically left-wing parties, the Left Alliance, are no less authoritarian than voters of the economically conservative parties, the Swedish People's Party among the citizens and the National Coalition among the elites.

DISCUSSION

The aim of our study was threefold: (1) to examine the role of authoritarianism in a multiparty system; (2) to assess how authoritarianism is associated with political orientation and policy preferences on both economic and cultural dimensions; and (3) to compare citizens and societal elites in terms of these aspects. Our results demonstrate that authoritarianism may be a politically important factor among both citizens and societal elites, not only in bipartisan systems such as that of the U.S., but also in a Nordic multiparty context.

In summary, our results suggest that authoritarianism is more closely related to political attitudes on cultural issues and culturally conservative political ideology than to attitudes on

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TABLE 4 Pairwise comparisons of levels of authoritarianism between parties among citizens.

	Estimate	*SE*	*t*	*p*
Christian Democrats—Swedish People's Party	1.232	.268	4.590	**<.001**
Christian Democrats—Left Alliance	1.075	.231	4.647	**<.001**
Christian Democrats—Green League	.987	.236	4.176	**.001**
Swedish People's Party—Finns Party	−.907	.183	−4.943	**<.001**
Other—Christian Democrats	−.868	.234	−3.714	**.006**
Left Alliance—Finns Party	−.751	.123	−6.127	**<.001**
Swedish People's Party—Centre Party	−.748	.185	−4.049	**.002**
Christian Democrats—National Coalition	.670	.224	2.999	.061
Christian Democrats—Social Democratic Party	.666	.223	2.988	.063
Green League—Finns Party	−.662	.130	−5.096	**<.001**
Left Alliance—Centre Party	−.592	.125	−4.717	**<.001**
Swedish People's Party—Social Democratic Party	−.566	.178	−3.174	**.036**
Swedish People's Party—National Coalition	−.561	.177	−3.163	**.038**
Other—Finns Party	−.544	.126	−4.325	**<.001**
Green League—Centre Party	−.503	.134	−3.762	**.005**
Christian Democrats—Centre Party	.483	.228	2.116	.439
Left Alliance—Social Democratic Party	−.409	.115	−3.550	**.010**
Left Alliance—National Coalition	−.405	.116	−3.483	**.013**
Other—Centre Party	−.385	.130	−2.971	.065
Other—Swedish People's Party	.363	.192	1.896	.594
Finns Party—National Coalition	.346	.107	3.237	**.029**
Social Democratic Party—Finns Party	−.341	.106	−3.209	**.032**
Christian Democrats—Finns Party	.325	.227	1.427	.877
Green League—Social Democratic Party	−.321	.125	−2.566	.185
Green League—National Coalition	−.316	.124	−2.556	.190
Swedish People's Party—Green League	−.245	.194	−1.264	.935
Other—Left Alliance	.207	.134	1.539	.823
Other—Social Democratic Party	−.202	.120	−1.685	.738
Other—National Coalition	−.198	.120	−1.645	.763
National Coalition—Centre Party	−.187	.110	−1.704	.726
Social Democratic Party—Centre Party	−.183	.109	−1.675	.744
Finns Party—Centre Party	.159	.117	1.353	.906
Swedish People's Party—Left Alliance	−.157	.189	−.829	.995
Other—Green League	.118	.141	.839	.995
Left Alliance—Green League	−.088	.138	−.639	.999
Social Democratic Party—National Coalition	.004	.098	.046	1.000

Note: Comparisons are presented in decreasing order by the magnitude of the estimate. *p*-values <.05 in bold.

economic issues and economically conservative political ideology. Authoritarianism is associated with economic and cultural policy preferences as well as both economic and cultural conservative identification. However, the associations between authoritarianism and cultural policy preferences and cultural conservative identification are stronger than the associations between authoritarianism and economic policy preferences and economic conservative

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TABLE 5 Pairwise comparisons of level of authoritarianism between parties among elites.

	Estimate	*SE*	*t*	*p*
Christian Democrats—Left Alliance	2.397	.397	6.039	**<.001**
Christian Democrats—Green League	2.227	.375	5.940	**<.001**
Christian Democrats—Social Democratic Party	1.973	.373	5.296	**<.001**
Christian Democrats—National Coalition	1.807	.369	4.898	**<.001**
Left Alliance—Finns Party	−1.576	.325	−4.843	**<.001**
Christian Democrats—Centre Party	1.467	.389	3.773	**.004**
Green League—Finns Party	−1.406	.309	−4.542	**<.001**
Christian Democrats—Swedish People's Party	1.331	.430	3.092	**.038**
Social Democratic Party—Finns Party	−1.152	.293	−3.927	**.002**
Swedish People's Party—Left Alliance	1.066	.310	3.443	**.012**
Finns Party—National Coalition	.986	.284	3.474	**.011**
Left Alliance—Centre Party	−.930	.237	−3.919	**.002**
Swedish People's Party—Green League	.896	.282	3.173	**.030**
Christian Democrats—Finns Party	.821	.455	1.806	.585
Green League—Centre Party	−.760	.209	−3.631	**.007**
Finns Party—Centre Party	.646	.311	2.075	.401
Swedish People's Party—Social Democratic Party	.643	.271	2.369	.234
Left Alliance—National Coalition	−.590	.202	−2.915	.063
Swedish People's Party—Finns Party	−.510	.368	−1.387	.845
Social Democratic Party—Centre Party	−.506	.189	−2.679	.117
Swedish People's Party—National Coalition	.476	.262	1.817	.577
Left Alliance—Social Democratic Party	−.424	.211	−2.006	.446
Green League—National Coalition	−.420	.166	−2.536	.163
National Coalition—Centre Party	−.340	.174	−1.954	.482
Green League—Social Democratic Party	−.253	.177	−1.429	.824
Left Alliance—Green League	−.170	.229	−.745	.995
Social Democratic Party—National Coalition	−.166	.141	−1.181	.927

Note: Comparisons are presented in decreasing order by the magnitude of the estimate. *p*-values <.05 in bold.

identification. A similar pattern is visible when examining the relationships with party preferences: Parties that differ regarding levels of authoritarianism most clearly also differ regarding cultural positions, rather than economic positions. While a kind of left–right divide might be visible, it is less apparent, and not all parties that are clearly at different ends of the economic spectrum differ in terms of their level of authoritarianism.

Our results agree with previous studies indicating authoritarianism to be connected to culturally conservative political opinions (e.g., Bakker et al., 2021; Engelhardt et al., 2021; Feldman, 2020; Luttig, 2017; Miller et al., 2017; Smith & Hanley, 2018). However, interestingly, our results contradict a previous study that found no association between authoritarianism and opinions on welfare issues in the U.S. (Bakker et al., 2021). In our study, higher levels of authoritarianism are associated with more conservative views on economic issues and more economically conservative identification among both citizens and elites. Thus, perhaps surprisingly, there might exist a relatively strong conservative authoritarianism, which extends to conservative economic views critical of welfare. This difference between the U.S. and Finnish contexts might derive from the exhaustion of the welfare models: The Nordic welfare model

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is more generous than its counterpart in the United States and may thus be viewed critically by citizens with relatively strong authoritarian views. In other words, authoritarianism could surface in different ways across countries and can be combined with different political views, depending on the context (see also Kivikangas et al., 2021).

Our results indicate that CRV are linked to party support on the liberal-conservative dimension in Finland. Voters for the Finns Party and the Christian Democrats were the most authoritarian, as these parties are more culturally conservative and traditional. The least authoritarian voters supported the Green League and the Left Alliance, parties generally considered more liberal and less traditional. Our results are compatible with previous findings suggesting that authoritarian CRV are associated with a higher probability of voting for Christian democratic parties and a lower probability of voting for green parties (Loughran, 2016). However, contrary to previous findings from France (Vasilopoulos & Lachat, 2018), we found no clear general trend of more authoritarian individuals voting for economically conservative rather than left-wing parties.

While the associations between authoritarianism and political orientation, policy preferences, and party support were found to be similar for citizens and elites, there is one notable difference. Among the elites, the relationship between authoritarianism and culturally conservative identification is notably stronger than between authoritarianism and both policy preferences and economic conservative identification. For citizens, the association between authoritarianism and culturally conservative identification is of similar strength as between authoritarianism and culturally conservative policy preferences, as were the associations with economically conservative identification and economically conservative policy preferences. This might indicate that policy preferences and political orientations are organized differently among citizens and elites. Specific policy preferences may be informed mainly by general political ideology among elites, whereas for citizens other factors (e.g., authoritarianism) affect policy preferences more directly or to a greater extent. Our results match those of previous studies that indicate that the association between authoritarianism and cultural conservatism is stronger among those with greater political engagement. However, as the policy preferences we measured differed significantly between our two samples, we cannot rule out that this difference was due to the specific policy preferences measured.

The strength of our study is the use of a population-based representative sample as well as our examination of the measurement of invariance across groups. Our study is the first to assess the validity of the CRV scale in the Finnish multiparty context. Based on our results, the CRV scale has acceptable validity and may offer a feasible way to measure authoritarianism in Finland. However, further efforts are required to determine its usability and validity in a variety of countries and political contexts.

The most obvious limitation of our study is its cross-sectional design, which did not allow us to determine the directions of the associations. Previous studies have indicated that the significance of CRV for political outcomes is not constant over time, and the causal direction might be such that the political context and how political elites frame currently relevant issues affect the CRV that individuals endorse (Luttig, 2017; Tucker et al., 2019). It is highly likely that the relationship between authoritarianism and policy preferences is a complex phenomenon, affected by political discourse and the rhetoric of political elites, which our study cannot fully capture. Our results may thus not be generalizable to other contexts.

Engelhardt et al. (2021) have revised the CRV scale, and the revised version offers better discrimination on the low and high ends of the scale. As the revised scale was published after our data collection, it was unfortunately not available to us. However, had we been able to use the revised scale, we should have seen stronger associations between authoritarianism and political outcomes (Engelhardt et al., 2021).

Our comparison of citizens and elites should be interpreted with caution. There were notably fewer respondents in the elite survey and voters of certain parties were severely underrepresented. While this makes our results regarding elites less reliable, the results do offer tentative insight into what role authoritarianism might play in various contexts.

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Our results should also be interpreted with caution regarding the prevalence of ideologically symmetrical authoritarianism. While our results suggest that authoritarianism is associated with conservative political orientations, it is unclear whether the CRV scale is capable of capturing authoritarianism in an ideologically neutral manner. The economic policy preferences included in this study also focused heavily on issues that would probably be more relevant to culturally conservative authoritarians and failed to capture political positions that would appeal to those authoritarians who might hold more culturally liberal positions (e.g., Costello et al., 2022). Future studies should examine the possible ideological bias of the CRV scale, and its connections to authoritarianism among the political left and liberals, to draw more general conclusions on how authoritarianism affects politics.

Moreover, child-rearing might be a special area that does not resonate in similar ways across societies and has different meanings in society. The measurement invariance of the CRV scale has not been extensively examined between countries. While our assessment of the validity of the scale in the Finnish context is a step in the right direction, more research is needed to establish that the CRV scale can be used appropriately to assess differences between countries.

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DATA AVAILABILITY STATEMENT

This study was not preregistered. Data and analysis code available upon request.

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